



Healing with Horsetail: Exploring plant kinship through ethographic art practices

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tinyurl.com/zt7pafkw



Introduction to the Problem

Problem: Harmful human practices -- instrumental use of plants as a natural resource

In response to multiple crises of ecological devastation, resource extraction,
& consumerism fueled by global economic and corporate dominance

Focus: Ancient forests as sites for social and ecological healing



Inspiration from work with an elder and an artist

Apprenticeship with Quw'utsun Elder, **Della Rice Sylvester** [1950-] in 2017-2018 (500+ hours) – embodied a vegetal, kinship perspective for healing *with* plants

Homecare, home share with artist and activist, **Marion Cumming** [1936-2022] – focused on embodied arts practices



2019 *Forest Meditation* – a collage of textured & colored papers, photographs, and organic matter on a tri-fold poster board (2' X 3').

Method: Multispecies Ethnography & Ethography



What shift of consciousness happens when we acknowledge plants in general—and horsetail in particular—as kin?

“Healing with Horsetail”:

- a vegetal, kinship perspective
- evolved through an experiential inquiry process
- slow, emergent, recursive, & rhizomatic

*See Supplemental Terms

Ethnographic art practices



Ethnographic art practices:

- deepened a connection to the land
- expressed complexity & sacredness of plant relationships
- embodied engagement / reciprocal relationships
- expanded researcher reflexivity

*See Supplemental Terms

Plants as Kin



Indigenous eco-centrism (Johnston, 2022)

- embeds animist and kincentric beliefs within a traditional lifestyle
- settler reminder to raise relational awareness about the value of ancient forest ecosystems
- not just critical of colonial constructs
- plants as autonomous, intelligent beings with agency

*See Supplemental Terms

Contemporary Ecological Animism



Engaged in contemporary ecological animism:

- relating to plants as kin
- exploring Druidry as an ancestral lineage
- utilizing visual ways of knowing
- witnessing intelligence of plants: aware of their kin, participate in social networks, demonstrate adaptability through corrective and innovative responses to their environment

*See Supplemental Terms

Druidry as a spiritual path

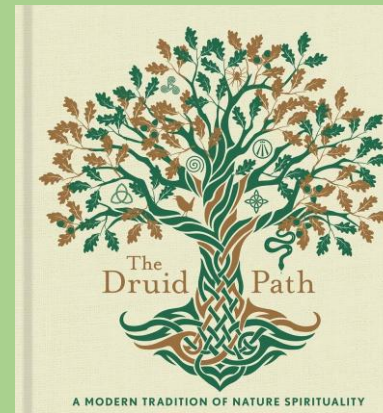
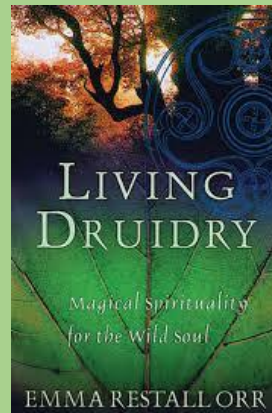
- adoptee and third-generation settler and colonizer
- identity – uprooted, fragmented, disjointed, and rhizomatic
- lacked deep-rooted cultural traditions to fully engage in Indigenous animism
- explored Indigenous roots through Celtic wisdom and Druidic traditions
- animist, nature-centric and relational worldview



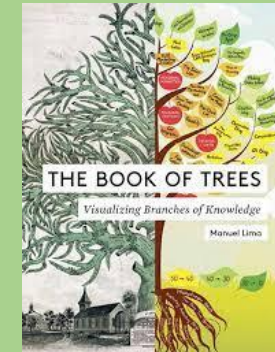
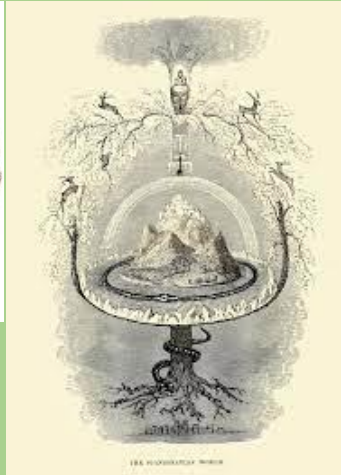
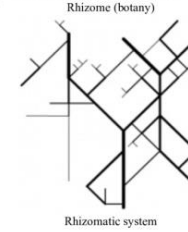
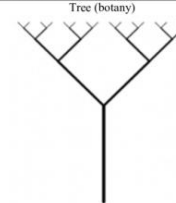
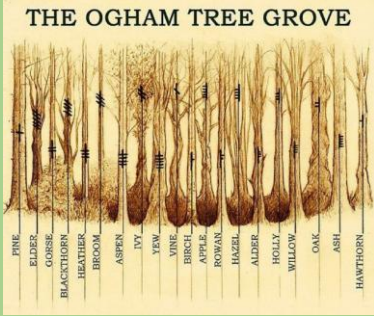
Animism is a monist metaphysical stance, based upon the idea that mind and matter are not distinct and separate substances but an integrated reality, rooted in nature.

— Emma Restall Orr —

AZ QUOTES



Visual Ways of Knowing



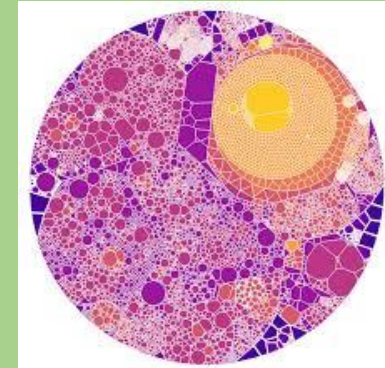
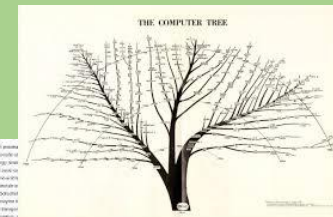
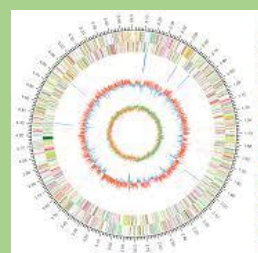
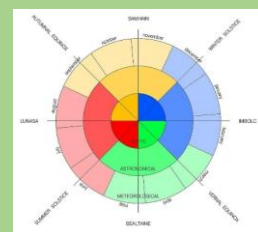
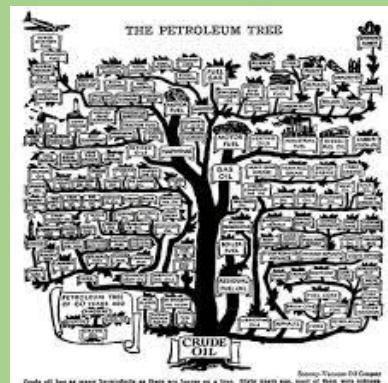
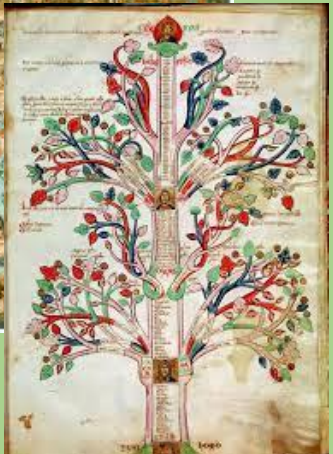
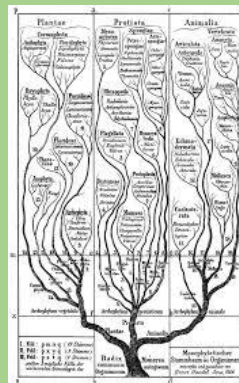
Deleuze & Guattari



Rhizomes

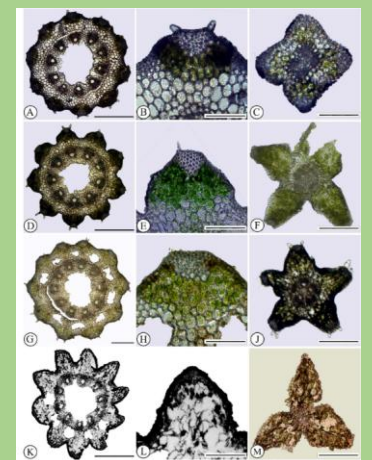
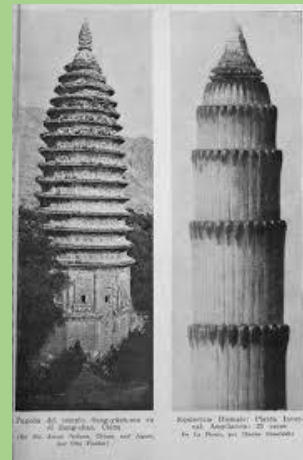
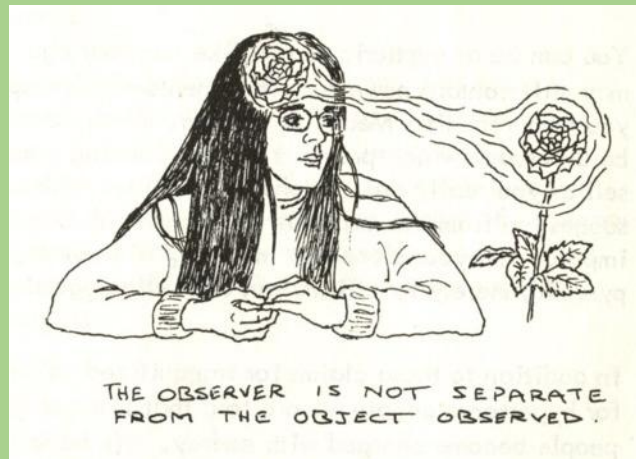


Anarchy of the Web



Data Gathering with Multispecies Ethnography

- research involved three cycles of data gathering, Spring 2022 to Summer 2023
- **multispecies ethnography** – a framework for linking art practices, narratives, and theory, while allowing for time for reflection and integration
- forest (or field) journal – internal dialogue and observations with multiple ways of knowing and perceiving (embodied, sensory, emotional, psychological, intellectual)



Cycle 1: Thematic Analysis - life/death cycle, rhythms of nature

- explored several locations in search of horsetail
- a deep healing response to the sudden and tragic loss of a friend
- Horsetail connected me with this new, recently departed “ancestor”
- communication in other space/time dimensions
- first major theme: seasons, cyclical stages of growth and development, with death and decay serving as nourishment for the next cycle of growth



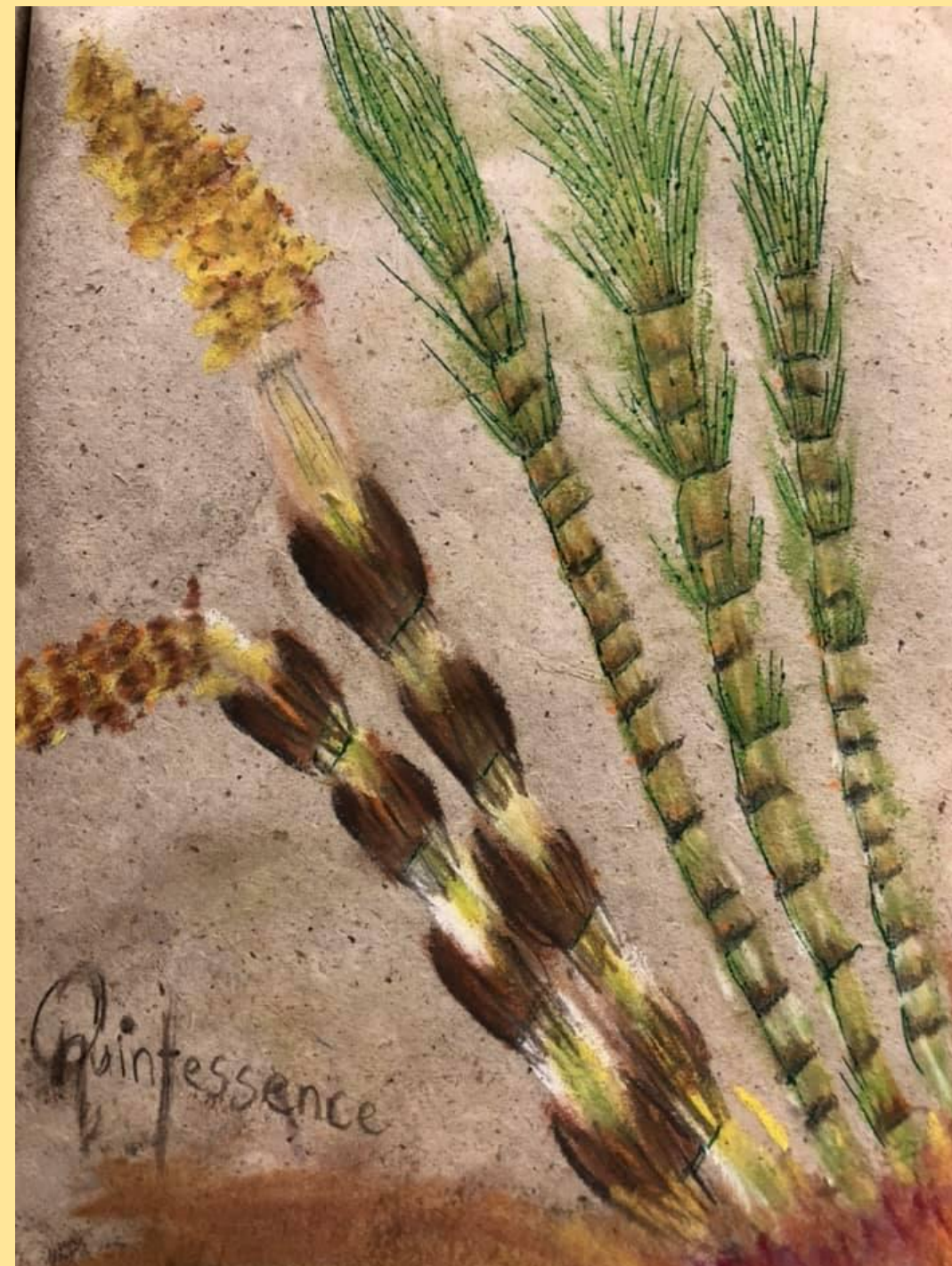
CYCLE 1 (Cont'd)

Spring &
Summer 2022

botanical sketches
Regatta Point Park

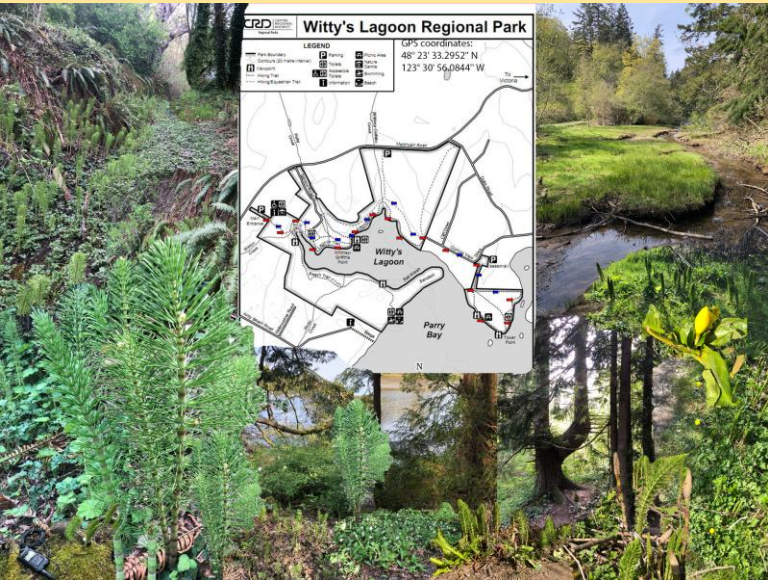


2022 Colored charcoal, water-based pens

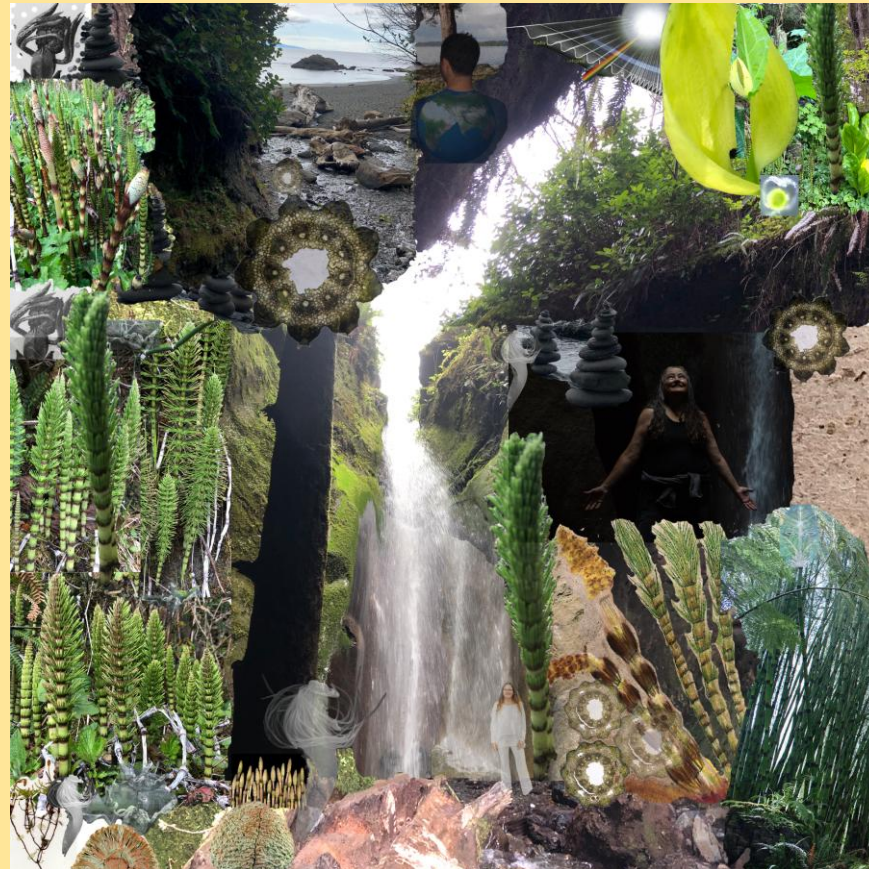


CYCLE 1

Digital collages



Witty's Lagoon, 2022 - field site collage



Sombrio Beach, April 2022 - horsetail at the waterfall



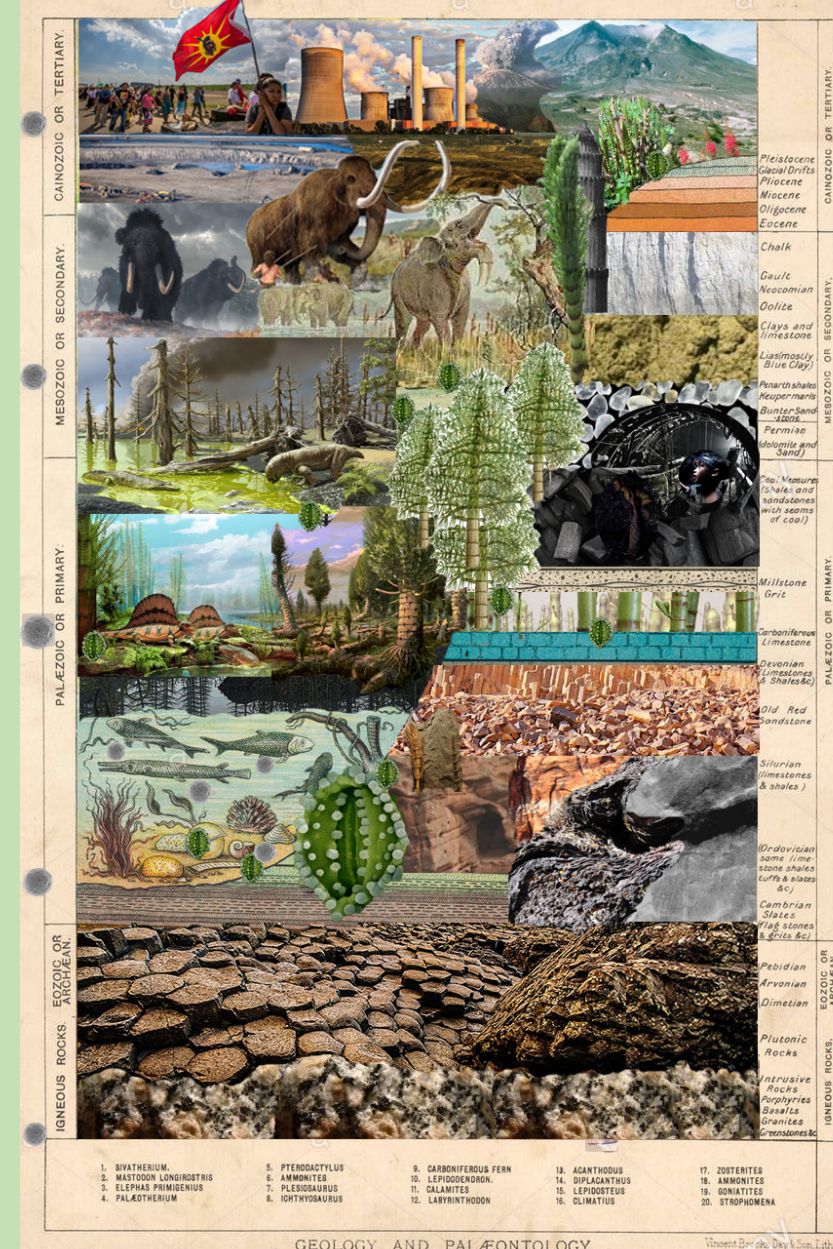
Surreal horsetail & swamp lantern,
April 2022

Cycle 2: Thematic Analysis - deep time, plant time



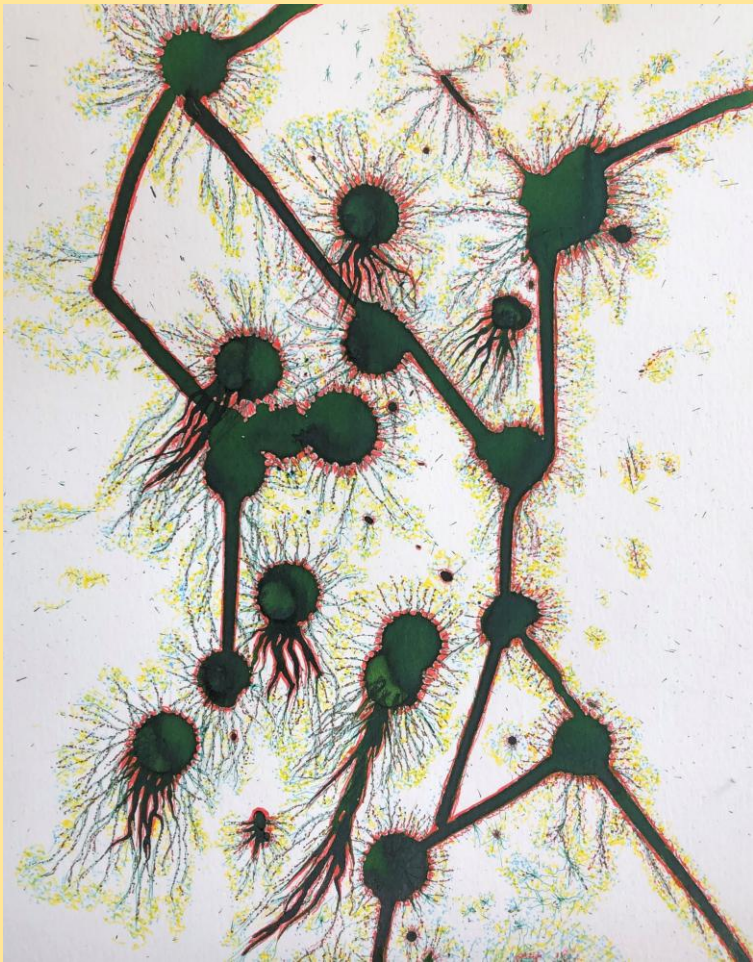
- thematic focus on the deep shifts to my concept of time
- Joanna Macy's concept of deep time as non-linear
- Michael Marder's treatise on "plant time"
- collage (on the right) illustrates the evolutionary relationship between humans and horsetail, with humans only appearing in a thin top layer

2021-2022 paleo-geological strata collage,
co-evolution of horsetail & humans

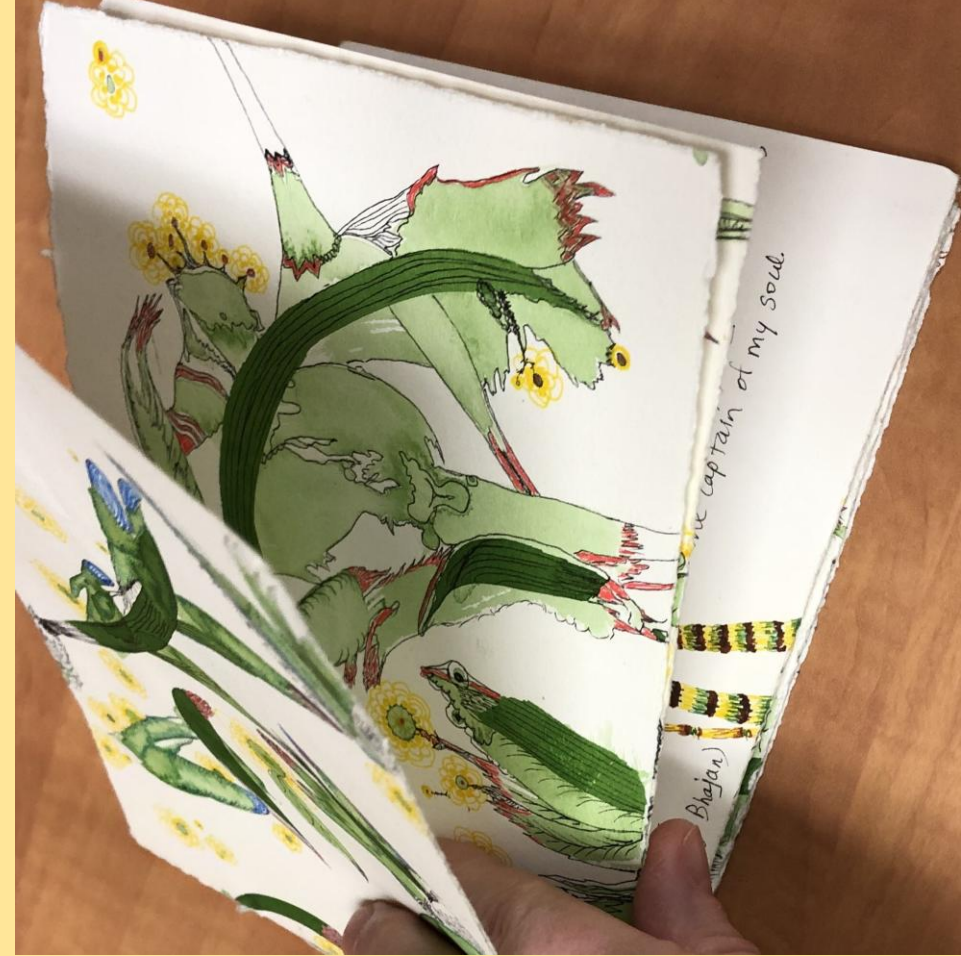


CYCLE 2 (Cont'd)

Art classes: exploring form
& imaginal realms



2022, *Sporangia* - Ink &
water-based pens



2022, *Metamorphology* – Art booklet, ink & water-based pens



CYCLE 2 (Cont'd)

Horsetail: listening with deer in the forest

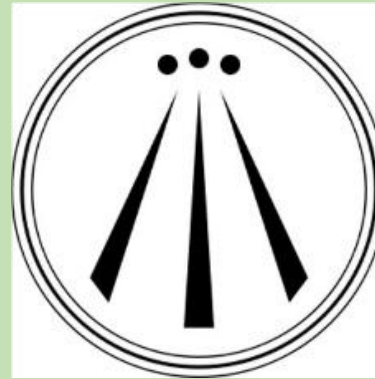


2022 Charcoal with inky
highlights



Cycle 3: Thematic Analysis - AWEN: Calas (Land), Gwyar (Sea), Nwfyre (Sky)

- two weeks gathering data at Sombrio
- a self-guided Druid initiation ritual
- a strong, energetic force at the waterfall site with cave-like entrance and portal
- inspired the next theme represented by the Druid symbol of “AWEN”
- the three lines represent this meeting place of land, sea, and sky



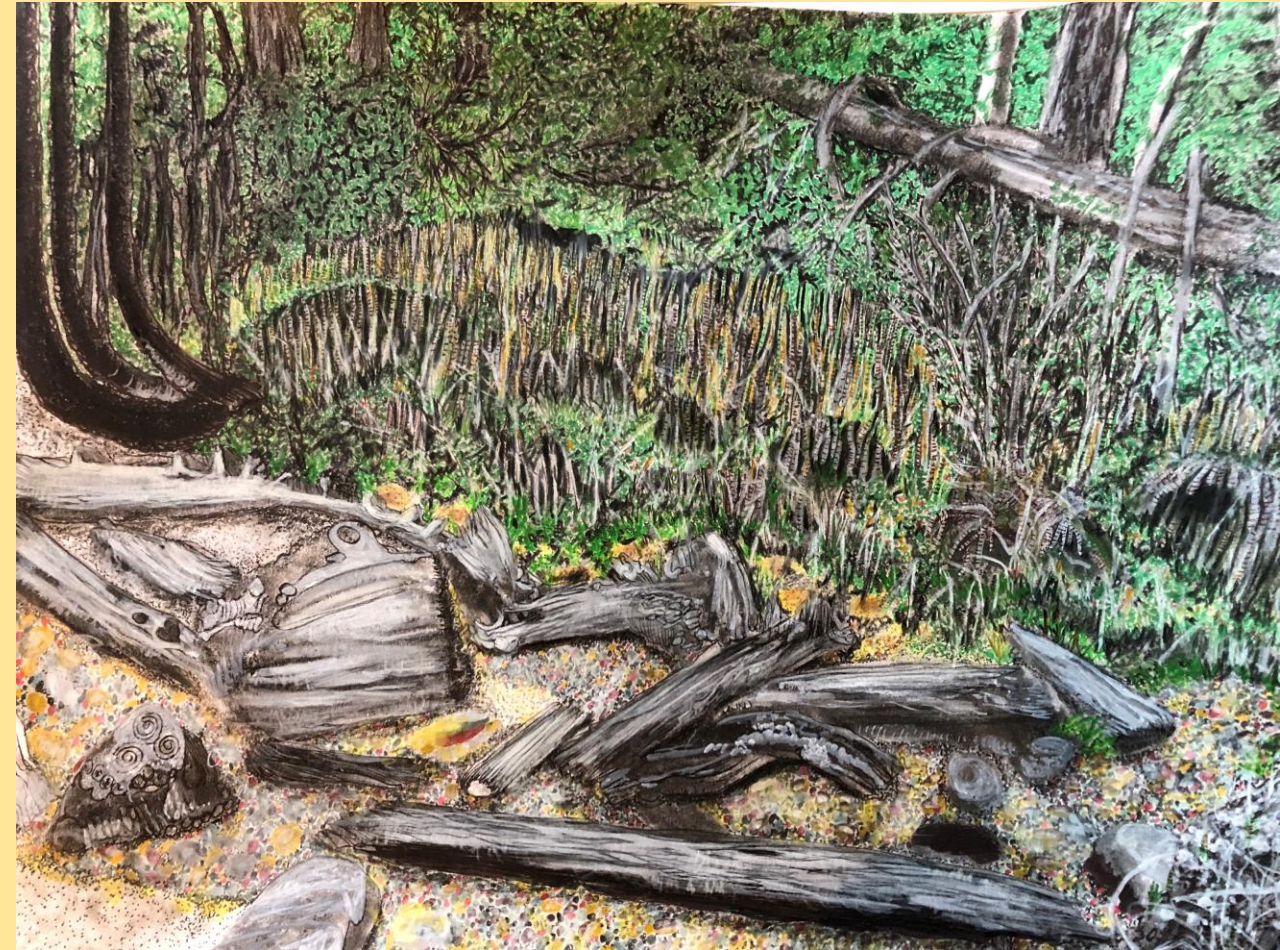


CYCLE 3 (Cont'd)

Evolving, embodied art practices



2023, Ditch site – Ink & water-based pens



2022, Waterfall site – Charcoal base, ink & water-based pens

CYCLE 3 (Cont'd)

Witnessing & re-imagining ecological community



2022, *Pacific eel bed* – Ink & water-based pens



2023, *Plantcestral memories* – Blue ink, charcoal, & water-based pens



2022, *Waterways with horsetail* – Ink & water-based pens

CYCLE 3 (Cont'd)

Listening
with
horsetail

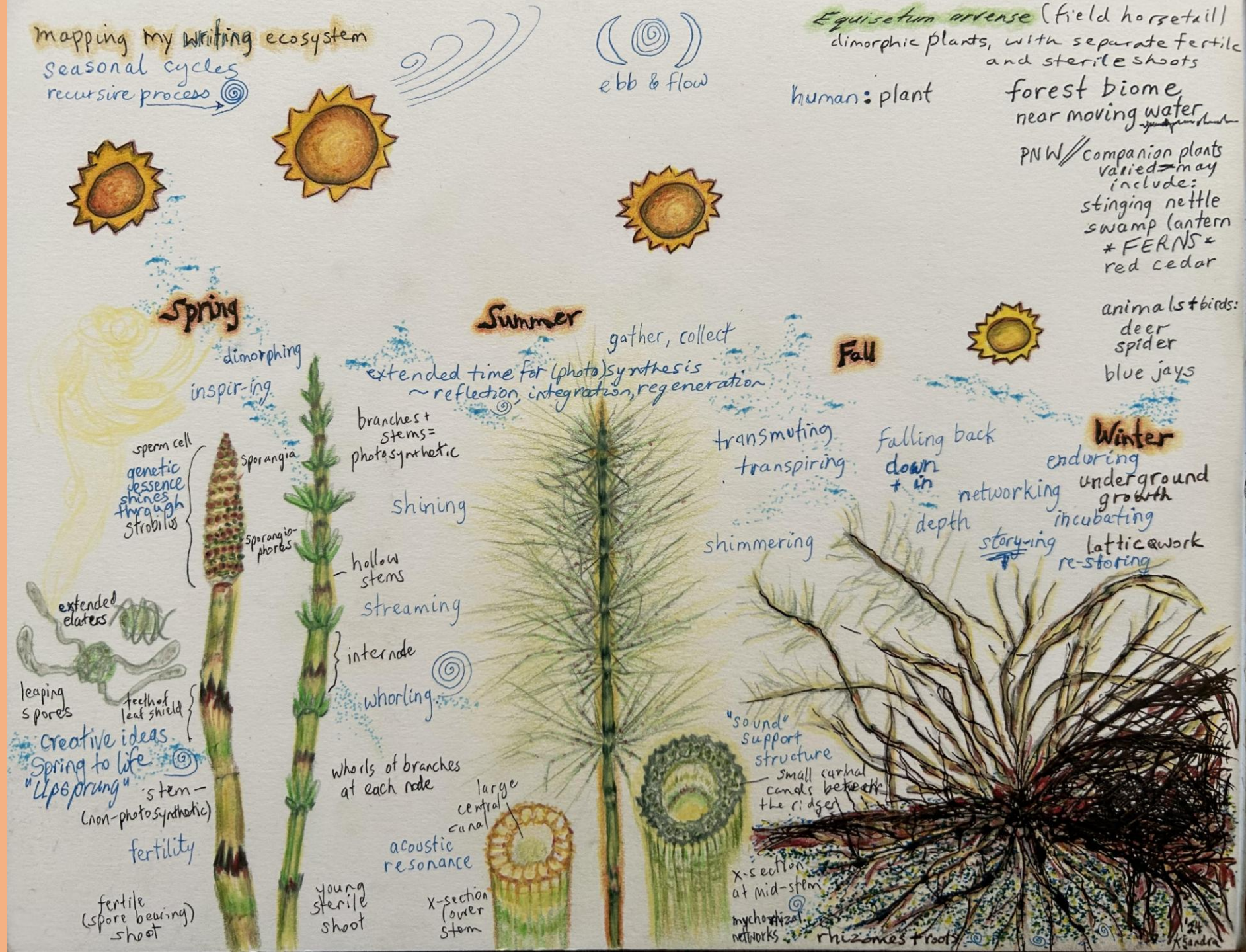


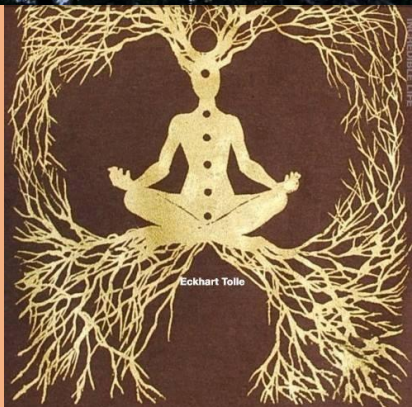
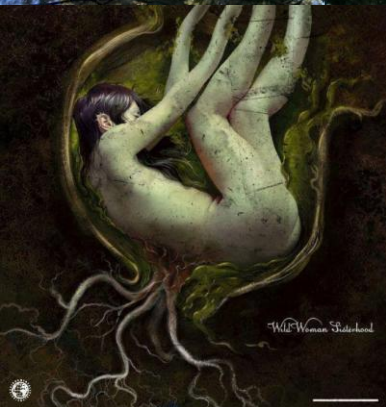
2023 Ink & water-based pens



Ecopoetic synthesis

- participated in community workshops
- arts-based, relational
- integration of knowledge & wisdom

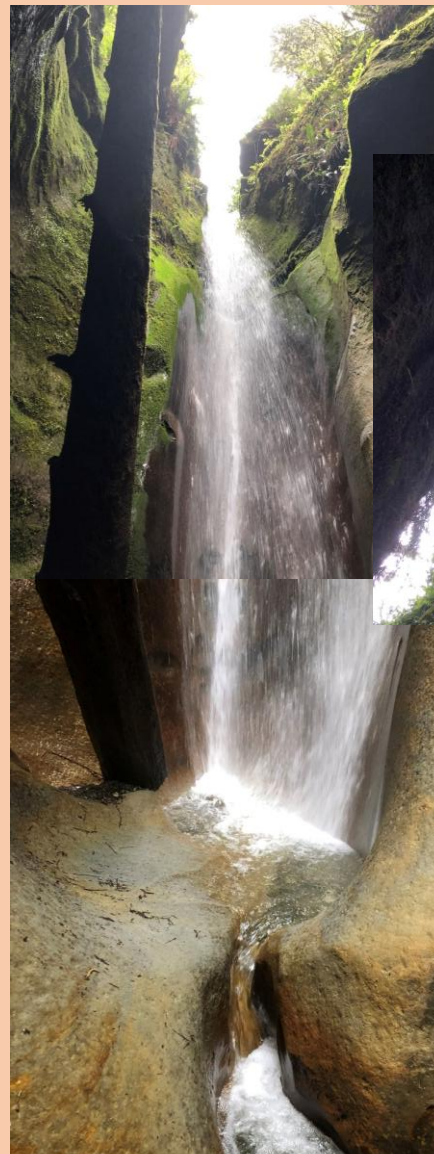




“to horsetail”
(*see handout)



“a horsetail proposition” (*see handout)



Conclusion



- Plants as interdependent ecological beings
- Plant kin embedded within multiple interconnected selves
- Ethnographic art practices – an ethic-focused way of integrating embodied encounters with plant kin:
 - opening the senses
 - actively listening
 - navigating an ecological self
 - radical inclusion of multiple species
- Supports social & ecological healing needed for radical transformation (Jeanine Canty, 2014)